But agree to what? Her mouth went dry. Delay. Find an excuse. He stepped closer. “All I ask is for you to hold me.”

“Hold you?” Her voice trembled.

“Yes.”

She had to stop herself from backing away as a beat of fear drummed in her mind. Maybe he would pin her down, and with no one in the office or the building, he could do as he pleased. Then his arms circled her shoulders, pulling her close. He was rigid, stiff. She had no choice but to crush down the fear and return his embrace. As she did, she felt a lightening, as if he was again the man she’d first met in the church eight months ago. Maybe human touch, denied to him for so long, had now revived him. When had he last been embraced or even touched by someone? Holding him, she listened to his steady heartbeat. Eventually, he let go.

“Thank you. It must be our secret,” he warned. “Frau Birks would not understand. She’s a bitter woman.”

“Yes. I won’t utter a word of it to anyone, I promise. Goodnight.”

Despite the darkness, Rose skipped down the stairs. She knew the steps by heart, had taken them nightly for months, just as she was sure she knew Reinhardt. He wasn’t a threat. He’d agreed to transfer André to Glashütte in return for a hug. It seemed ridiculous, even too easy. She stopped halfway, wondering if she’d missed something.

A chill along her spine. What if it was too easy and he and Frau Birks were working together to set her up, and she couldn’t see it? Why had he stopped asking her about Josef, and what was happening at the sick bay? At the back of her mind, a faint voice warned that something was off, but she couldn’t pinpoint what and further she didn’t want to believe it because all that mattered was getting André out of Berlin.

She was searching for problems that didn’t exist. Reinhardt was still a human being, despite the evil things he believed or did, and that gave her hope. She’d spent a year in Germany and survived. André would soon be by her side. With him, Rose had the courage to face whatever awaited in the coming year.